THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

“OUT LOUD, BUT QUIETLY”

October 18, 2010 – September 26, 2011
Hollywood • London • View Park • New York City

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

PART ONE: BRINGING THEM HOME

INT. PARAMOUNT PICTURES - EXECUTIVE BUILDING - CONFERENCE ROOM - MELROSE AVENUE, HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, OCTOBER 18, 2010 - 8:00 A.M. PDT

The historic Paramount lot. Through the window, the famous Bronson Gate and the water tower. A polished conference room. On one side: BRAD GREY (52), chairman and CEO of Paramount Pictures, sharp and dapper, flanked by two business-affairs executives. On the other side: NATASHA BULLOCK (49), alone except for LENORA HAYES (45), on loan from Marvel for the morning.

A term sheet sits on the table between them.

BRAD GREY
Natasha. You bought the house. Now you want the furniture.

NATASHA
I bought the house, Brad. And you're still living in two of the bedrooms.

BRAD GREY
(smiling)
We have a contract. THE AVENGERS and IRON MAN 3 are Paramount releases. That deal was signed in 2005, when nobody in this town would touch Marvel with a ten-foot pole. We took the risk.

NATASHA
And you've been well paid for it. Four Marvel films. Two of the biggest openings in Paramount's history. Your distribution fee on IRON MAN 2 alone could buy a small island.

BRAD GREY
It did, actually. Fiji. Very nice.

A beat. Lenora suppresses a smile. Natasha doesn't.

NATASHA
Here's my offer. Donohue takes over worldwide distribution of THE AVENGERS and IRON MAN 3. Paramount receives a minimum guarantee of one hundred and fifteen million dollars, plus eight percent of THE AVENGERS' worldwide gross and nine percent of IRON MAN 3's. You keep your logo on both films.

(beat)
You don't lift a finger. You don't spend a dollar on marketing. You get paid for a movie you don't have to sell.

Brad Grey picks up the term sheet. Reads it. Hands it to his business-affairs executive, who reads it and nods almost imperceptibly.

BRAD GREY
And if I say no?

NATASHA
Then in May 2012, the biggest film in the history of the world opens with a Paramount logo on it, and Donohue's marketing team, the largest in the industry, decides they're very busy that month.

BRAD GREY
(laughing, delighted)
That's a threat.

NATASHA
It's a calendar.

Grey leans back. He looks at Natasha for a long moment, the look of one predator recognizing another.

BRAD GREY
Your father used to do this to my old boss in 1988. He'd come to lunch, eat half a salad, and walk out with the studio's lunch money.

NATASHA
He taught me to finish the salad.

Grey laughs again. He picks up a pen.

BRAD GREY
Eight and nine. And our logo stays on the poster. Same size as yours.

NATASHA
Same size.

He signs. She signs. Lenora gathers the papers with the speed of a woman who has seen deals collapse in the elevator.

BRAD GREY
(standing, offering his hand)
Congratulations. You own the Avengers. All of them.

NATASHA
(shaking it)
No, Brad. The Avengers own themselves. I just own the projectors.

CUT TO:

DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT / PARAMOUNT PICTURES - JOINT ANNOUNCEMENT - MONDAY, OCTOBER 18, 2010

DONOHUE TO DISTRIBUTE MARVEL'S 'THE AVENGERS' AND 'IRON MAN 3'

Paramount receives a minimum of $115 million plus a share of each film's worldwide gross. "Thor" and "Captain America: The First Avenger" remain Paramount releases in 2011.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "DONOHUE BUYS BACK AVENGERS DISTRIBUTION FROM PARAMOUNT" (Page 1 of 66)

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Oct 18, 9:12 AM)
So Donohue now owns Marvel AND distributes the Avengers. The Mouse House has the whole universe.

ShellHead1963 (Oct 18, 9:20 AM)
$115 million to buy back a movie from Paramount. Paramount gets 8% of the gross for doing nothing. Natasha Bullock is either a genius or she has a lot of faith in that movie. Probably both.

NoNerfsPlz (Oct 18, 9:31 AM)
Read the fine print: Donohue's marketing machine is the biggest in Hollywood. Donohueland rides. Happy Meal-style tie-ins. Every kid on Earth is going to know what the Avengers are by May 2012.

WarMachineRox (Oct 18, 9:45 AM)
As long as Feige's still in charge, I don't care whose logo is on the poster.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 20, 2010 - 9:00 P.M. PDT

DESMOND (53) sits behind his desk. Across from him: ESTHER (28) and BRENDA OKAFOR (57), Esther's lawyer, a folder in her lap. On the desk: a thick document, "SMILLEY MANAGEMENT GROUP - AMENDED AND EXTENDED REPRESENTATION AGREEMENT - TERM: THROUGH DECEMBER 31, 2017."

DESMOND
It's a standard extension, sweetheart. Three more years. Better commission terms for you. It protects you.

BRENDA
(without looking up from the document)
Page six gives Smilley Management approval rights over "all publicity appearances, social media and personal public conduct." Page nine extends your commission to "any income derived from any source whatsoever," including endorsements and real estate. Page fourteen is my favorite. "Client shall not enter into any personal or business relationship that, in Manager's sole judgment, would damage Client's brand."

(finally looking up)
Desmond. I've been a lawyer for thirty-one years. That isn't a management contract. That's a chastity belt.

Desmond's jaw tightens. He doesn't look at Brenda. He looks at his daughter.

DESMOND
Esther. I'm your father. Everything I do, I do to protect you.

ESTHER
(quietly)
Then you don't need page fourteen, Daddy.

A long silence. Brenda slides the contract back across the desk.

BRENDA
My client respectfully declines the extension. Her current agreement remains in force through 2014, as written. Have a good evening, Mr. Smilley.

Brenda stands. Esther stands. At the door, Esther stops and looks back at her father, alone behind his big desk.

ESTHER
I love you, Daddy. I'm just not going to let you decide who I love.

She leaves. Desmond stares at page fourteen for a long time. Then he picks up a pen and, slowly, draws a line through it. He doesn't sign anything. He just sits there.

CUT TO:

PART TWO: LONDON

EXT. BATTERSEA POWER STATION - LONDON - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 25, 2011 - 7:00 A.M. BST - DAY ONE OF "THE AVENGERS"

The colossal, abandoned brick power station on the Thames, four white chimneys against a gray English sky. Transformed by the Marvel art department into a secret S.H.I.E.L.D. research facility, the site where Loki first strikes. Practical sets fill the turbine hall: real scaffolding, real catwalks, real steel.

Trailers line the riverbank. A banner over the catering tent: "WELCOME, EARTH'S MIGHTIEST - DAY 1 OF 104."

JOSS WHEDON (46) stands on an apple box in front of the entire assembled cast, all in costume for the first time, together.

MARC-ANTHONY (29) in the Mark VII armor (the helmet under his arm). ESTHER (28) in Thor's silver and crimson, Mjolnir in hand. TYRESE AVERY (29) in Cap's modern blue uniform. AMOND BAKER (29) in a gray motion-capture suit covered in dots. ELXA BULLOCK (30) in the Wasp's gold and black. DAVID TIPTON (30) in Ant-Man's red suit and helmet. HARMONY DIVINE (28) in Black Widow's black catsuit. ARIANNA CUMMINGS (28) with Hawkeye's bow. SAMUEL L. JACKSON (62) as Fury. CLARK GREGG (49) as Coulson. TOM HIDDLESTON (30) as Loki, in full horned helmet.

WHEDON
Okay. I'm going to say something nerdy, and then we're going to work for a hundred and four days.

(beat)
Forty-eight years ago, Stan Lee and Jack Kirby put five people on the cover of a comic book. They didn't know if anyone would buy it. Nobody thought heroes this different could ever be on the same page.

(gesturing at all of them)
Look at you. You're on the same page.

Silence. Then Samuel L. Jackson, in full Fury costume, slowly starts to clap. Everyone joins in.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON
Now let's go kick Loki's ass.

HIDDLESTON
(wounded, pressing a hand to his chest)
I'm standing right here, Sam.

CUT TO:

INT. THE SAVOY HOTEL - CAST LOUNGE - LONDON - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 29, 2011 - 11:00 A.M. BST - THE ROYAL WEDDING

A UK bank holiday. Production is shut down for the day. The whole cast is crammed into a hotel lounge in front of a giant TV, watching the wedding of Prince William and Catherine Middleton at Westminster Abbey. Tea, scones, champagne.

On screen: the new couple emerges from the Abbey to the roar of a million people lining the streets.

HARMONY
(dabbing her eyes)
Two billion people are watching this.

AMOND
Two billion people and me. I've never cried at a stranger's wedding before.

HARMONY
(handing him a napkin without looking)
You cry at insurance commercials, Amond.

AMOND
That one with the dog was very moving.

Across the room, Tyrese and Arianna are betting on how many seconds the balcony kiss will last. Elxa and David are critiquing the dress. Hiddleston is narrating everything in a perfect BBC commentator's voice.

At the window, apart from the group: Marc-Anthony and Esther. Watching the TV, but standing very close.

ESTHER
(quietly)
They waited a long time too. Eight years, they said on the news.

MARC-ANTHONY
Amateurs. We're at seventeen.

ESTHER
Seventeen if you count from the Kids' Choice Awards.

MARC-ANTHONY
I always count from the Kids' Choice Awards.

On screen, the couple kisses on the balcony of Buckingham Palace. The room cheers. Esther turns her head and looks at him.

ESTHER
We're in London, Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY
(very still)
I noticed.

ESTHER
Tonight. Nine o'clock. Bring a coat.

She walks back to the group before he can answer. Marc-Anthony stands at the window, completely frozen, while a million people cheer on the TV behind him.

Amond, across the room, sees his face. He raises his eyebrows. Marc-Anthony shakes his head: not now. Amond grins and goes back to the wedding.

CUT TO:

EXT. SHAKESPEARE'S GLOBE - BANKSIDE, LONDON - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 29, 2011 - 9:00 P.M. BST

London is still celebrating. Distant music. Union Jacks in every window. Down on the South Bank, the reconstructed Elizabethan theater sits dark, its thatched roof against the night sky.

A side door opens. KENNETH BRANAGH (50) peeks out in a scarf and coat, holding a ring of keys.

BRANAGH
(whispering)
You have one hour. The night watchman thinks I'm rehearsing a sonnet. If anyone asks, you were never here, and I am a very responsible man.

Marc-Anthony steps out of the shadows in a long coat, holding a thermos and two paper cups.

MARC-ANTHONY
Ken. Thank you. I owe you forever.

BRANAGH
You owe me a cameo in IRON MAN 3. As a butler. With an accent.

(holding the door, then pausing)
She doesn't know it's here?

MARC-ANTHONY
She told me to bring a coat. I brought a theater.

BRANAGH
(moved, quietly)
Her grandfather played Henry the Fifth for Joe Papp in 1963. She told me in the garage audition. She said he never got to play the Globe.

(beat)
Go on. Make him proud.

INT. SHAKESPEARE'S GLOBE - THE YARD AND STAGE - CONTINUOUS

The open-air yard is empty. Moonlight pours down through the round opening in the roof onto the painted wooden stage. Silence. The ghost of four hundred years.

Esther walks in from the far entrance in a long coat, a scarf over her hair. She stops dead in the yard, looking up at the galleries, at the stage, at the moon.

ESTHER
(barely a whisper)
Marc. How did you...

MARC-ANTHONY
(from the stage)
A Shakespearean director owed me a favor. Well. He owes me one now. Technically I owe him a butler.

She walks slowly to the edge of the stage, looking up at him. He holds out a hand. She takes it and steps up onto the boards.

She stands at center stage and turns around in a slow circle, taking in the empty galleries.

ESTHER
Granddaddy never got to stand here. He always said it was his only regret. The only stage in the world he wanted.

MARC-ANTHONY
Then do it for him.

She looks at him. Then she closes her eyes. Breathes the way Cornelius taught her: from the diaphragm. And speaks into the empty theater, her voice rising up into the night.

ESTHER
"We few, we happy few, we band of brothers. For he today that sheds his blood with me shall be my brother..."

Her voice fills the Globe. Marc-Anthony stands at the edge of the stage, watching her, not breathing. She finishes the speech and opens her eyes. Tears are running down her face.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
(softly)
He'd have loved this.

MARC-ANTHONY
Esther.

She turns. He's standing a few feet away, in the moonlight, hands in his coat pockets. Suddenly, for the first time in his life, the most charming man in Hollywood looks nervous.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
I'm in London.

ESTHER
(a small, teary laugh)
I noticed.

MARC-ANTHONY
You told me to ask you again in London. So.

(a deep breath)
Esther Smilley. I've been in love with you since I was twenty-four and liking you since I was eleven and holding your pencil since 1994. I don't care about the Oath or the feud or Page fourteen or anything else your father writes in a contract. I don't want to hide anymore. Will you be with me? Out loud?

A long silence in the empty theater. The moon overhead. Esther looks at him, and her face does something it has never done in front of a camera: it lets go completely.

ESTHER
Yes.

(stepping closer)
Out loud. Yes.

She steps forward, takes his face in both hands, and kisses him. In the middle of the Globe stage. Under the open sky. In the moonlight. The first kiss, seventeen years in the making.

When they finally pull apart, both of them are laughing and crying.

MARC-ANTHONY
(breathless)
That was better than the Kids' Choice Awards.

ESTHER
You threw up on nobody's shoes. It was a big improvement.

From the dark doorway at the back of the yard, a soft voice:

BRANAGH (O.S.)
(sniffling)
...Bloody marvelous.

They both turn, startled. Branagh is standing in the shadows, wiping his eyes with his scarf.

BRANAGH (CONT'D)
Sorry. Occupational hazard. I'll just be... watching a sonnet. Elsewhere.

He disappears. Esther buries her face in Marc-Anthony's coat, laughing.

CUT TO:

EXT. MILLENNIUM BRIDGE - LONDON - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 29, 2011 - 10:40 P.M. BST

They walk hand in hand across the footbridge toward St. Paul's Cathedral, lit gold against the night sky. Fireworks from a royal wedding party somewhere downriver. Nobody recognizes them in their scarves and coats. Or if anyone does, they're too busy celebrating to care.

ESTHER
We have to be careful. For a while. My father...

MARC-ANTHONY
I know.

ESTHER
Not forever. Just until I figure out how to tell him.

MARC-ANTHONY
We've been careful for seventeen years. A few more months won't kill me.

(beat)
Probably.

She stops in the middle of the bridge and kisses him again, under the fireworks.

ESTHER
Out loud, Marc. But quietly.

MARC-ANTHONY
Out loud. But quietly. Got it.

Somewhere behind them, a TOURIST (20s) with a digital camera is photographing the fireworks. In the corner of one of her pictures, two blurry figures are kissing on the bridge. She won't notice them until she uploads the photos to Flickr three weeks later.

CUT TO:

PART THREE: THOR

INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - GREEN ROOM - HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 2, 2011 - 4:30 P.M. PDT - THE THOR PREMIERE

A crowded green room. Every TV is tuned to CNN: "OSAMA BIN LADEN KILLED BY U.S. FORCES IN PAKISTAN." Footage from late last night of crowds outside the White House and at Ground Zero in New York. The cast and crew watch in silence.

ESTHER (28), in a robe, makeup half done, stands with TOM HIDDLESTON (30), KENNETH BRANAGH (50) and KEVIN FEIGE (37). Lenora is on the phone.

LENORA
(hanging up)
Paramount says the premiere goes ahead. No change. They want it to be respectful. No pyrotechnics on the carpet. No thunder effects.

FEIGE
Good.

Esther watches the footage of people in New York weeping at Ground Zero.

ESTHER
(quietly)
Ten years.

BRANAGH
Strange day to show a film about a god coming down to Earth to protect it.

HIDDLESTON
Maybe it's exactly the right day.

The door opens. MARC-ANTHONY (29) leans in, in a dark suit, flown back from London with her the night before. His eyes find Esther across the room. For one second, everyone in the room can see exactly what they are. Then he puts on his public face.

MARC-ANTHONY
Just came to say break a leg, Your Majesty.

ESTHER
(smiling, very public)
Thank you, Mr. Bullock.

He leaves. Hiddleston leans over to Esther.

HIDDLESTON
(whispering)
"Mr. Bullock." Really?

ESTHER
(whispering back)
Shut up, brother.

HIDDLESTON
Ken told me everything. The Globe. Henry the Fifth. He cried for an hour on set the next morning. Didn't get a single shot done.

ESTHER
(covering her face)
Oh, no.

CUT TO:

EXT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - HOLLYWOOD BOULEVARD - EVENING

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 2, 2011 - 6:15 P.M. PDT

The red carpet. Marquee: "THOR - WORLD PREMIERE." A towering practical replica of the Destroyer armor looms in the forecourt. Thousands of fans, many little girls in homemade Thor capes with plastic hammers.

A black car pulls up. Out steps CORNELIUS SMILLEY (77) in a perfect black suit, his cane polished. Then HATTIE (75). Then SIMONE (31). Then CELESTE SMILLEY (51), in a gold dress, head held high.

The press line goes absolutely insane.

ACCESS HOLLYWOOD CORRESPONDENT
The Smilleys! At a Donohue-owned premiere! Cornelius! Mr. Smilley! Why are you here?

CORNELIUS
(calm, regal, leaning on his cane)
My granddaughter is Thor, young man. I'd walk into the sun for that.

ACCESS HOLLYWOOD CORRESPONDENT
And Desmond? Esther's father?

A pause. Celeste steps forward, with the poise of a former Ebony Fashion Fair model.

CELESTE
My husband is at home. He sends his love to our daughter.

Behind her, Simone raises an eyebrow. That last part was a lie, and the whole family knows it.

Then Esther arrives in a sleek silver gown with a crimson cape trailing behind her. The crowd SCREAMS. Hundreds of little girls in plastic capes scream loudest of all. She goes straight to the barricade and spends ten minutes signing plastic hammers, ignoring the publicist tapping her watch.

A LITTLE GIRL (6), in a cape made from a red towel, holds up her toy hammer.

LITTLE GIRL
Am I worthy?

Esther kneels down to her level on the red carpet.

ESTHER
What's your name?

LITTLE GIRL
Kayla.

ESTHER
Kayla, nobody gets to decide that except you. Are you worthy?

KAYLA
(thinking hard, then nodding firmly)
Yes.

ESTHER
Then you are.

She signs the hammer: "To Kayla, who is worthy - Thor." The girl's mother bursts into tears. Thirty cameras capture it. It will be the most-shared photo of the night.

CUT TO:

INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - LOBBY - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 2, 2011 - 6:50 P.M. PDT

The ornate gold-and-red lobby is packed with guests heading to their seats. Through the crowd, two groups are moving toward each other without realizing it.

From the left: VICTOR DONOHUE (74) and JOAN (73), with NATASHA (49), ROBERT (52), ELXA (30), GRACE (17), and MARC-ANTHONY.

From the right: CORNELIUS SMILLEY (77) and HATTIE (75), with CELESTE (51) and SIMONE (31).

The crowd parts. The two old men see each other at the same moment, across about twenty feet of red carpet.

The lobby goes silent. Not everyone, but everyone who knows. Photographers' flashes stop. A publicist freezes mid-sentence.

Victor Donohue and Cornelius Smilley stand perfectly still, looking at each other. Two men who shared a Harlem rooftop in 1958. Who haven't been in the same room since a courtroom in 1971.

Forty years pass between them in five seconds.

Joan's hand tightens on Victor's arm. Hattie's hand tightens on Cornelius's. Marc-Anthony and Esther, from opposite sides, both stop breathing.

Then, slowly, Cornelius lifts his chin. Just slightly. A nod. Barely a nod.

And Victor, very slowly, nods back.

That's all. A nod. Then an usher says, "Ladies and gentlemen, please take your seats," and the spell breaks. The two families move off toward opposite aisles.

Celeste, passing Marc-Anthony in the crowd, stops for exactly one second. She looks up at him.

CELESTE
(very quietly)
You're more handsome than in the paper-crown pictures.

She keeps walking. Marc-Anthony stares after her, stunned. Simone, behind her mother, winks at him.

CUT TO:

INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 2, 2011 - 8:40 P.M. PDT

On screen: New Mexico. Thor, banished, powerless, in the rain, sees the Destroyer burning a small town. She walks out into the street, alone and mortal, to face it. To save her friends. The Destroyer strikes her down. She dies in the dust.

And in the crater miles away, Mjolnir trembles. Rises. Flies through the sky. Into her outstretched hand. Lightning EXPLODES. Thor rises in full armor, crimson cape, silver helm.

The El Capitan ERUPTS. People on their feet. Screaming. Little girls standing on their seats with plastic hammers raised.

In the second row, Cornelius Smilley is weeping openly, his hand over his heart. Hattie holds his arm.

CORNELIUS
(whispering)
That's my girl. That's my girl.

Across the aisle, three rows back, Victor Donohue watches Cornelius weep. He doesn't look at the screen anymore. He just watches his old friend.

CUT TO:

INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - LATER

SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 2, 2011 - 9:20 P.M. PDT

Post-credits. A S.H.I.E.L.D. bunker. Nick Fury leads Dr. Erik Selvig down a hallway to a metal case. Fury opens it. A glowing blue cube.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (ON SCREEN, AS FURY)
The Cosmic Cube. Power without limit. The Red Skull wanted it in 1943. Somebody else wants it now.

Selvig's reflection in the glass smiles a sly, wicked smile: Loki's smile.

The audience gasps. "COSMIC CUBE!" someone screams. The comic book fans in the theater go wild. "THE AVENGERS - MAY 4, 2012."

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - THOR OPENS

SUPER: FRIDAY, MAY 6 - SUNDAY, MAY 8, 2011

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL THOR DISCUSSION - SPOILERS" (Page 1 of 431)

NoNerfsPlz (May 6, 12:15 AM)
She DIED for those people. Powerless. And the hammer came back because she was finally worthy. I cried for ten minutes. She is worthy. She is WORTHY.

ShellHead1963 (May 6, 12:30 AM)
The Bifrost bridge was a real structure built on a real Icelandic glacier. The frost giants were practical suits. The Destroyer was a real 12-foot armor. Apology #212: I was worried female Thor would be a gimmick. It's the most Shakespearean superhero movie ever made.

Mjolnir_Worthy (May 6, 12:45 AM)
Thor lifts the hammer in a rainstorm, lightning, cape, the whole theater stood up. Female Thor skeptics: I was one of you. I'm not anymore.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (May 6, 1:00 AM)
"Cosmic Cube." They used the REAL comic name. Red Skull wanted it in 1943. That's the CAP movie in July. It all connects.

WarMachineRox (May 6, 1:20 AM)
Did everybody see Cornelius Smilley and Victor Donohue NOD at each other in the El Capitan lobby? There's a photo. It's the most dramatic photo I've ever seen and nobody even says anything in it.

Repulsor_Ray (May 6, 1:40 AM)
that photo of esther kneeling down to the little girl with the towel cape. "am i worthy?" "nobody gets to decide that except you." i'm not okay

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - FRIDAY, MAY 6, 2011

#Thor - #SheIsWorthy - Kayla - The Nod - Cosmic Cube - Esther Smilley

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

esthersmilley: to every little girl who came to the premiere in a cape made from a towel: you are worthy. you always were. #Thor 1:15 AM May 6th from Twitter for iPhone

marcanthonyb: saw thor at the el capitan. she died in the street and came back with lightning. best movie of the year. i am biased. i am also right 9:30 AM May 6th from Twitter for iPhone

amondbaker: thor and hulk fight in the avengers. i've already lost. i've accepted it. #SheIsWorthy 10:12 AM May 6th from web

DEADLINE.COM - SUNDAY, MAY 8, 2011, 9:45 AM PT

THOR THUNDERS: $78.6M OPENING! MARVEL 6-FOR-6

Branagh's Shakespearean epic and its lightning-rod star have silenced the skeptics. Friday $28.4M, Saturday $27.6M, an estimated $22.6M Sunday. CinemaScore "A." 89% on Rotten Tomatoes. It's not "Iron Man" money, but for a movie critics called "a gamble with a hammer," it's a triumph. And I'm told women made up 52% of the opening-weekend audience, unheard of for a superhero film.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - CORNELIUS'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 8, 2011 - 10:00 A.M. PDT - MOTHER'S DAY

Cornelius (77) sits in his leather chair, a copy of the L.A. TIMES Calendar section open on his lap. The front page: two photos side by side. Esther kneeling to the little girl in the towel cape. And, below it, a grainy shot from the El Capitan lobby: Cornelius and Victor, twenty feet apart, nodding.

Headline: "THE NOD."

DESMOND (53) stands in the doorway. He hasn't spoken to his father since the premiere.

DESMOND
You went.

CORNELIUS
I went.

DESMOND
You took Mama. You took Celeste. You took Simone. You stood in a Donohue theater and nodded at Victor Donohue in front of the whole world.

CORNELIUS
I watched my granddaughter die in the street and come back with lightning in her hand. With my Henry the Fifth in her voice. I'd have nodded at the Devil himself to be in that room.

DESMOND
(his voice rising)
He took EVERYTHING from you!

Cornelius closes the newspaper. Looks up at his son.

CORNELIUS
Sit down, Desmond.

DESMOND
I don't want to...

CORNELIUS
SIT DOWN.

The old man's voice, the voice that once filled Central Park, fills the study. Desmond sits.

CORNELIUS (CONT'D)
(quieter now)
I want to tell you something I have never told anybody. On election night, I called Victor Donohue.

Desmond freezes.

DESMOND
Natasha Bullock told me. At the Polo Lounge. I didn't believe her.

CORNELIUS
Believe her. I dialed his number from memory. I still know it. 1958, it was a phone in a hallway on 135th Street. In 2008, it's a phone in Bel Air. I let it ring once and I hung up. Because I was afraid. Not of him. Of me. Of finding out I'd been wrong for forty years.

(beat)
And on Monday night, I watched him watch me cry. And he didn't look away. He didn't gloat. He just... looked at me like it was 1958.

Desmond stares at his father. Something is shifting inside him. He fights it.

DESMOND
And Esther? The Bullock boy?

CORNELIUS
You already know, son. You've known for a year. You knew when you saw the rooftop pictures. You knew in Hall H when she grabbed his hand.

(leaning forward)
The question isn't whether she loves him. The question is whether you're going to make her choose between him and you. Because if you do, son, I promise you, she will choose him. And you'll spend forty years staring at a telephone, like me.

A long, terrible silence. Desmond stands. He walks to the window. His shoulders are shaking. Cornelius doesn't move.

Finally, without turning around, Desmond speaks.

DESMOND
(barely audible)
I don't know how to stop, Daddy.

CORNELIUS
(gently)
I know. Neither did I.

CUT TO:

PART FOUR: NEW YORK

EXT. PARK AVENUE AT 40TH STREET - MANHATTAN - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 15, 2011 - 6:40 A.M. EDT - DAY 76 OF "THE AVENGERS"

Park Avenue, shut down for six blocks. The Marvel Method at full scale: real wrecked cars. Real rubble trucked in by the ton. A Grand Central Terminal facade with real scorch marks. The viaduct strewn with practical debris. Hundreds of extras covered in dust. Barricades at every intersection, packed with thousands of New Yorkers and fans filming on their iPhones.

In the middle of the avenue, AMOND BAKER (29), in his gray motion-capture suit with a head-mounted camera rig, faces ESTHER (28), in full Thor armor with Mjolnir. It's the climactic fight from AVENGERS #1: Loki has tricked the Hulk into believing Thor is his enemy.

WHEDON
(through a megaphone)
Remember, Amond, you're nine feet tall and Loki has poisoned your mind. Esther, he's your friend, and you don't want to hurt him. But you will.

AMOND
(shaking out his arms)
I've been practicing being nine feet tall in my bathroom mirror.

ESTHER
I've been practicing not hurting you in my bathroom mirror.

WHEDON
And... ACTION!

Amond ROARS, a deep, guttural sound that makes extras two blocks away flinch, and charges down Park Avenue. Esther plants her feet, raises Mjolnir, and meets him head-on. They slam together. Real impact pads. Real wire rigs. Real dust exploding around them.

The crowd behind the barricades SCREAMS.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
CUT! That's... that's it. That's the take.

Amond lies flat on his back on Park Avenue, gasping. Esther stands over him, holding out a hand.

ESTHER
You okay, big guy?

AMOND
(taking her hand, wheezing)
Puny god. Very... strong... puny god.

Behind the barricade, a FAN (20s) yells: "HULK! WHO WINS?" Amond, still on the ground, raises one arm and points at Esther.

AMOND
(shouting)
SHE DOES! SHE ALWAYS DOES!

The crowd roars with laughter.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE - MONDAY, AUGUST 15, 2011

NYCmarvelgirl (7:02 AM)
THEY ARE FILMING THE AVENGERS ON PARK AVE RIGHT NOW. THE HULK JUST TACKLED THOR IN FRONT OF GRAND CENTRAL. THIS IS MY COMMUTE

setphotoleaks (7:20 AM)
first look at the full Thor armor on location. silver, crimson cape, winged helm. comic accurate down to the rivets #Avengers

midtownmike (8:15 AM)
i'm late for work because the hulk is lying in the middle of park avenue. worth it

comicshopdan (9:45 AM)
6 customers this morning asked for Avengers #1. I'm out. I'm OUT. Thank you, Park Avenue

CUT TO:

BOX OFFICE MOJO - SUNDAY, JULY 24, 2011

'CAPTAIN AMERICA: THE FIRST AVENGER' SALUTES WITH $71.4 MILLION OPENING

Tyrese Avery's Steve Rogers debuts on his 30th birthday weekend. Marvel goes 7-for-7. Post-credits: Fury finds Steve, frozen in the Arctic ice, and the screen cuts to black: "THE AVENGERS - MAY 2012."

CUT TO:

EXT. THE AVENGERS - ARCTIC ICE SET - BROOKLYN NAVY YARD - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, AUGUST 23, 2011 - 2:30 A.M. EDT

A massive practical set built inside a historic dry dock: a frozen Arctic plane wreck, real ice by the ton, refrigeration units roaring. Tyrese lies inside a block of genuine ice in his Captain America uniform, the shield on his chest, a breathing tube hidden in his collar.

The other founders stand around the ice, flashlights in hand, in costume: Marc-Anthony, Esther, Elxa, David. This is AVENGERS #4. The team finds Cap in the ice.

ELXA (AS JANET)
(shining her light on the frozen face)
Hank. There's a man in there.

DAVID (AS HANK)
That's not just a man. Look at the shield.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
(very quietly, for once without a joke)
My father spent his whole life looking for him.

WHEDON
Cut! Beautiful. Get Tyrese out of the ice before he becomes an actual popsicle!

Crew rush in. Tyrese emerges from the ice, shivering violently, wrapped instantly in heated blankets.

TYRESE
(teeth chattering)
Th-th-that's the most C-C-Captain America thing I've ever done.

MARC-ANTHONY
You were in there for eleven minutes, Cap.

TYRESE
G-g-granddaddy walked through the Ardennes in the snow for six weeks. I can d-do eleven minutes.

CUT TO:

EXT. PARK AVENUE - THE AVENGERS WRAP - NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 10, 2011 - 11:30 P.M. EDT - DAY 104 OF 104

The final shot is done. The whole crew, hundreds of people, gathers on the closed avenue under work lights. Whedon stands on top of a wrecked taxi with a megaphone.

WHEDON
Ladies and gentlemen, that is a WRAP on THE AVENGERS!

A deafening cheer. Champagne corks pop. Crew members hug. Amond lifts David off the ground. Harmony and Arianna do a choreographed victory dance. Tyrese and Samuel L. Jackson salute each other. Elxa is crying.

Whedon raises his hand for quiet.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
Before everyone gets drunk on Park Avenue, which the city has specifically asked us not to do... tomorrow is September eleventh. Ten years. Some of you were in this city that morning. Some of our crew were first responders.

(beat)
We just spent four months blowing up New York and putting it back together, and every one of us did it for real, on these streets. Tomorrow, let's go remember the people who did it for real too.

Silence. Then quiet applause. Feige, standing beside Lenora, puts an arm around her shoulders.

CUT TO:

EXT. NATIONAL SEPTEMBER 11 MEMORIAL - LOWER MANHATTAN - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 11, 2011 - 9:00 A.M. EDT - TENTH ANNIVERSARY

The memorial's twin reflecting pools, newly opened, water falling into the footprints of the towers. Families of the victims. Bagpipes. Names being read.

Among the crowd, behind the families, the Avengers cast stands quietly, unannounced, in dark clothes, no cameras, no publicists. Tyrese holds his hand over his heart. Samuel L. Jackson has his head bowed. Amond and Harmony stand side by side. Arianna wipes her eyes.

At the edge of the group, Marc-Anthony and Esther stand together. In public. Their hands are intertwined at their sides. Not hidden. Not obvious. Just held.

A bell tolls at 9:03 a.m. The moment the second plane hit. Silence across the plaza.

Esther leans her head on Marc-Anthony's shoulder. He kisses her hair.

Nobody notices. Or if they do, nobody says anything. Today isn't about them.

CUT TO:

EXT. HUDSON RIVER PARK - LOWER MANHATTAN - SUNSET

SUPER: SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 11, 2011 - 7:15 P.M. EDT

Two beams of light, the Tribute in Light, begin to rise into the darkening sky from the site of the towers. Marc-Anthony and Esther sit on a bench by the river, alone, watching them.

ESTHER
Four and a half months.

MARC-ANTHONY
Since the Globe.

ESTHER
It's the happiest I've ever been in my life.

(beat, quieter)
Granddaddy told Daddy he's going to lose me if he makes me choose. Simone heard the whole thing through the wall. She says Daddy cried.

MARC-ANTHONY
(surprised)
Your father cried?

ESTHER
She says he said, "I don't know how to stop."

A long pause. The beams of light reach higher.

MARC-ANTHONY
Then maybe we help him.

ESTHER
How?

MARC-ANTHONY
I don't know yet. But you don't stop a forty-year war by winning it. You stop it by inviting the other side to dinner.

Esther looks at him. Then she smiles and puts her head on his shoulder.

ESTHER
My mother wants to meet you properly. Not for one second in a lobby.

MARC-ANTHONY
Name the day.

ESTHER
Thanksgiving. At Simone's apartment. Not the house. Just Mama, Simone, Granddaddy, Grandmama. And you.

MARC-ANTHONY
And your father?

ESTHER
One step at a time, Marc.

They sit together as the twin beams climb into the night sky. Out loud. But quietly.

FADE OUT.

HEADLINES

VARIETY - MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 12, 2011

'AVENGERS' WRAPS IN NEW YORK AFTER 104 DAYS ON LOCATION

Whedon's ensemble shot entirely on real locations in London and Manhattan with practical sets; cast observed the 9/11 anniversary at the memorial, unannounced. Release: May 4, 2012, through Donohue.

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - (Issue of Sept. 23, 2011)

THE NOD: Inside the El Capitan Moment That Stopped Hollywood

Victor Donohue and Cornelius Smilley haven't spoken since 1971. On "Thor's" premiere night, they didn't speak either. They didn't have to.

TMZ.COM - (Posted Sept. 14, 2011)

IRON MAN & THOR HOLD HANDS AT 9/11 MEMORIAL?!

A blurry photo from the 10th anniversary ceremony appears to show Marc-Anthony Bullock and Esther Smilley holding hands. Both camps declined to comment. Also surfacing on Flickr: a tourist's photo from London's Millennium Bridge on the night of the Royal Wedding. Is that them? It's blurry. It's also definitely them.

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of Sept. 26, 2011)

Romeo and Juliet Go Public? Not Quite.

Sources say View Park's crown jewel and Bel Air's favorite son have been an item since April. Sources ALSO say Esther's mother, grandmother and grandfather approve. Her father? "Working on it," says one insider.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER THIRTEEN